



“ ”

Scientific principles and evidence have demystified so much of the practice.

Science of Yoga is the book I wanted to read when I first started practicing yoga. In classes, teachers offer (sometimes conflicting) cues and claims—“Calm your nervous system by elongating your exhales;” “This pose will boost your immunity;” “Align your knee over your ankle”—and I constantly wondered, “Why?”

For the past decade, through workshops, reading research papers, and completing my Master of Science in yoga therapy at Maryland University of Integrative Health, I have continued to fill my notebooks with facts, figures, sketches, and stories. *Science of Yoga* summarizes the notes I found most fascinating as a yoga student and teacher. This book is intended as neither a comprehensive text on human anatomy and yoga, nor a medical reference book; it is just the beginning. My intention is for this material to spark more curiosity and discussion about the science of yoga, and lead to more inspired yoga practitioners and professionals, more rigorous research, more public policies that encourage yoga in schools and healthcare, and, ultimately, more accessibility and acceptance.

Through my research, scientific principles and evidence have demystified so much of the practice. Surprisingly, this made my transformative experiences feel even more magical. There is just so much more

to discover. In the grand scheme of scientific inquiry, yoga research is in its infancy. However, now is an exciting and pivotal point in the field, with a remarkable increase in the quality and quantity of yoga research papers in the past few decades; the evidence supporting yoga's benefits continues to grow rapidly.

Science can explain the hows and whys of many things, but research studies, no matter how rigorously conducted, cannot compare to your personal, experiential evidence of healing and transformation. Only you can harness the power of yoga through practice. As with any scientific inquiry, I hope this book leaves you with more questions than answers, and brings out your inner child to playfully enquire, “Why?”

Be well,

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, likely belonging to Ann Swanson. The signature is fluid and cursive, with a prominent loop at the end.

Ann Swanson

Mind-body science educator and certified yoga therapist
www.AnnSwansonWellness.com